

Comparatives and Superlatives

A It is common in ICT to make comparisons and find differences while describing the properties of IT equipment. When you want to buy a new device, or you read articles about the latest computer or smartphone, or need to make a decision about the most suitable ICT system for you, you might have to use comparative adjectives and adverbs.

Qualitative adjectives (*якісні прикметники*) have the **positive degree** (*основна форма*), the **comparative degree** (*вищий ступінь порівняння*) and the **superlative degree** (*найвищий ступінь порівняння*).

B The comparative and superlative degrees of adjectives are formed in two ways:

1. all one-syllable and most two-syllable adjectives (including those ending in **-y**, **-er**, **-le**, **-ow** and those having stress on the second syllable) form the degrees of comparison by means of the endings **-er** and **-est** (e.g., slow – slower – slowest);
2. other two-syllable adjectives as well as adjectives of three or more syllables form their degrees of comparison using the words **more/less** and **(the) most/least** (e.g., difficult – less difficult – least difficult).

Adverbs have the same degrees of comparison as adjectives:

1. one- and two-syllable adverbs form their degrees of comparison by means of the endings **-er**, **-est** (e.g., fast – faster – fastest);
2. adverbs of more than one syllable form their degrees of comparison by means of the words **more/less** and **(the) most/least** (e.g., quietly – more quietly – most quietly).

C If an adjective or an adverb ends in **-e**, we add **-r** or **-st** (e.g., large – larger – largest).

If an adjective or an adverb ends in **-y** preceded by a consonant, the **-y** is changed into **-i** before the ending **-er** and **-est** (e.g., easy – easier – easiest).

If the adjective ends in one consonant preceded by a short vowel, the final consonant is doubled before **-er** and **-est** (e.g., big – bigger – biggest).

There is also a small group of words that form the degrees of comparison in their individual way:

good / well – better – best

bad(ly) – worse – worst

much / many – more – most

little – less – least

far – farther, further – farthest, furthest

D We use comparative adjectives and adverbs to show change or make comparisons:

- While consoles are a **better** option if you just want to play games, PCs support more applications and are **easier** to upgrade.
- In the computer world, the **smaller** the device, the more it costs.

The comparative degree can be emphasized by means of the words **much**, **far**, **a lot**:

- Apple computers tend to be **a lot more** expensive than Windows computers.

To express similarity or differences, the adjective or adverb in the positive degree can be placed within **(not) as... as** or **not so... as**:

- Free programs are **as good as** proprietary ones.
- Backup in a hard disk partition is **not so reliable as** a cloud-based system.

E We use superlative adjectives and adverbs to describe the noun that has the highest or lowest degree of a characteristic:

- Windows is **the most popular** operating system in the world.
- This is **the least expensive** laptop in the store.

